by Norman as ‘paravata’, which is similar to the Jaina ‘parevaya’ or turtle dove. But the influences and rationale of the list are difficult to conclusively establish because it includes birds like geese and doves that are likely to have been widely enjoyed in a way that queen ants and bats were not. If Hultzsch is right and the creature in Ashoka’s list is a rhinoceros, a general anti-brahmanism could be detected: the *Manu Smriti* suggests that eating rhinos pleases dead ancestors, specifically enjoining that its flesh be eaten by the ‘twice-born’ because this satisfies ‘the manes for endless times’.[36]

The zoologist Sunder Lal Hora, who specialized in fish and fisheries, points out that there are five species of fish in the list that are inedible and therefore not worth the killing. These are sharks and boneless fish (‘Anathikamachhe’), eels or fish easily eluding the grasp (‘Vedaveyake’), the porpoise, or a fish-like animal with a lumpy body (‘Gamgapuputake’), skate or ray (‘Samkujamchhe’), and globe-fish or a fish like a porcupine with the ability to feign death when in danger (‘Kaphatasayake’).[37] These five varieties, he says, are not consumed even in modern India, because—

> Globe-fishes and their allies are poisonous and should not be eaten. Unless properly treated, the flesh of Sharks, Rays, and Skates is bitter to taste and gritty on account of the deposition of uric acid crystals in their flesh. The Gangetic Porpoise is revered among the Hindus of the Indo-Gangetic Plain and its flesh is not eaten. With the exception of certain parts of South India, eels are not eaten on account of their strong resemblance to snakes. It would thus appear that the present-day prejudices of not eating these fishes are as old as the Asoka period.[38]

Culinary habits are culturally formed and what Hora shows as undesirable species had much to do with the traditional Hindu society of his own time. But over the same period, tribal and fishing communities may well have had more catholic tastes and not adhered to such taboos. Ashoka may well have been addressing fishing communities in which virtually anything caught was cooked.

The prohibitions required on certain days may well have been for sound environmental reasons. The days against catching fish were the fourteenth